



ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

Enhanced international footprint: Recently, S.P. Jain Group acquired California Miramar University to open its sixth global campus in the US. This may encourage other Indian B-schools to set up campuses in similar locations.

International rankings: As many as 14 Indian B-schools found place among the Top 100 in *FT*'s business school ranking this year, up from 11 in 2023. Further, eight Indian B-schools ranked in LinkedIn's 2024 Top 100 MBA programmes for career outcomes, particularly for networking. The enhanced international reputation would aid Indian B-schools and their alumni.

Launch of online MBA by IIM Ahmedabad: Earlier this year, IIM Ahmedabad launched an online MBA for working executives, which is welcome news for those who wanted an MBA degree from an IIM, without leaving jobs. Several IIMs may follow.

While cheering on the good news, it is important to reflect on some sour stories and trends of this year.

● **Poorer placements:** Placement is undoubtedly the most important barometer of MBA-admission deci-

sion making. The placements of MBA batch 2022-24 were dismal, even at the top B-schools, including many IIMs.

Average salaries declined: The average salary offered for domestic placements in the Top 25 B-schools dropped nearly 5% to ₹22.7 lakh from ₹23.88 lakh in 2023. The decline was to the extent of 15% in a few cases.

Extended placement season: Some leading B-schools failed to get 100% campus placements, despite extended placement sessions. This year, several B-schools extended their placement season multiple times.

Highest offers plummeted: The highest salaries offered at many B-schools have significantly decreased compared to previous years, affecting not only regular MBAs but also executive MBAs.

Lesser international placements: International placements got a big jolt at several campuses, both in terms of the number of offers and the salary packages offered.

In fact, many B-schools were seen leveraging their alumni networks aggressively to secure placements for the outgoing batch. Considering placement is a key reason for students to go in for management studies, this may hurt the MBA's appeal in India.

● **Lower ROI (return on investments):** ROI has declined significantly as the average salary packages offered have decreased and course fees have increased. This has hampered students' repayment capabilities for education loans. In fact, RBI's recent concern about the rising NPA for education loans confirms this fact.

● **Closure of courses:** The past two years have seen the discontinuation of 111 AICTE-approved and hundreds of non-regulated management courses. Due to low demand, some executive programmes, even by IIMs and the top B-schools, have been terminated.

Overall, management education is undergoing rapid transformation and experimentation. Artificial intelligence, technological advancements, sustainability concerns versus consumerism—these factors will only accelerate the speed of experimentation, failures and transformations. The tough competition could benefit students, recruiters and academia, as institutes offering subpar management education are likely to shut down. Top quality Indian MBA colleges have tremendous scope to grow—both in attracting domestic students and in competing on a global scale for international aspirants. **BT**

Views are personal